

Disadvantaged NO MORE

A chain of state-run residential schools for Dalit and tribal students turns into a breeding ground for excellence

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

When 16-year-old Nitin Tandekar from Dindori district in Mahakoshal topped the high school exams in Madhya Pradesh, he didn't merely breach a preserve of the privileged. He became the unofficial mascot of students from historically disadvantaged backgrounds who have achieved remarkable success in academics in different corners of the state. While the results of the high school and higher secondary exams of the Madhya Pradesh Board were dismal, Dalit and tribal education has been the lone bright spark in the state's surrounding gloom.

With a pass percentage of 88 per cent in high school exams, Dalit students studying in state-run residential schools have done remarkably well compared to those belonging to the general category in all results. Likewise, the overall pass percentage for higher secondary exams under the Madhya Pradesh Board was 65 per cent while it was 87 per cent in the residential schools run by the Scheduled Caste development department. A similar motivation runs in the residential schools for tribal students called the Eklavya Adarsh Avasiya Schools that are run by a state-level society headed by the tribal Development Department Minister.



PANKAJ TIWARI

The confidence that the success in academics has bred among students is written large on their faces. The newly constructed building of a residential school in the Morod Gram Panchayat for Dalit students can rival most mid-sized schools in nearby Indore. From its small premises shared with a model school, the school shifted to a new campus this year. Vandana Bhalseeh, a Class VII student, who hails from the Balai community loves her hostel life.

There is a reason for her fierce attachment to the school. It offers her facilities she couldn't have imagined back home. "This hostel is better than any hotel. I have my own cupboard, study table and bed," she says. There are 112 girls in this residential school, besides 135 boys who have a separate hostel. Pramod Tukaram Bartane, a Class VII student from the Jatav community, doesn't want to return home to Khandwa to run his father's grocery business. "I



“Our success shows that the concept of residential schools works. Things are on the right track.”

D.D. SHRIVASTAVA, Principal, Residential School for Dalits, Indore